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Watercolor painting by artist David Baker shows the strange creature who allegedly helped abduct Betty and Barney Hill in the White Mountains of New Hampshire.

HYPNOSIS AND THE HILL ABDUCTION CASE

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EDITORIAL

ROSWELL AND THE GAO INVESTIGATION

By now most of you will have heard about the inquiry into the Roswell crash requested by Congressman Steven Schiff of New Mexico. Rep. Schiff requested that the General Accounting Office (GAO), the investigative branch of Congress, undertake this inquiry. There have been reports about the request in various media since the story broke in January, including the *Washington Post*, *The Albuquerque Journal*, UFO periodicals, and a UFO program broadcast by the Fox network.

The various reports about Schiff's request have been somewhat contradictory, so to clarify the nature of the GAO inquiry, I recently spoke in person with the two GAO staffers directly responsible for the investigation.

Steven Schiff has been trying—on behalf of his constituents and others—to get an answer about what happened at Roswell since early in 1993 (efforts in the UFO community to generate Congressional interest in Roswell began in 1990). In this he has been singularly unsuccessful, though not due to lack of effort, as every government agency contacted either denied responsibility, passed his request to another agency, or didn't bother to respond. Rep. Schiff mentioned this lack of responsiveness and assistance to GAO Comptroller General Charles A. Bowsher last fall in what was otherwise a routine meeting. That conversation led, after some initial discussions and negotiations, to the initiation of a formal investigation by the GAO that began early in 1994.

The GAO conducts many studies every year into government operations (1,380 in 1992). Normally those inquiries take one of two directions (which can be and often are combined). First, the GAO investigates how and where the government has been spending money, to see if an agency's programs have operated according to the restrictions of Congressional mandate and in an efficient manner (remember those \$500 Pentagon screwdrivers?). Second, the GAO investigates whether government agencies and personnel have followed proper policies and procedures, again as mandated by law, existing regulations, or other applicable standards. In both types of work, the GAO often reviews samples of relevant records, rather than trying to collect all records of a certain type, to look for patterns and evidence for government action or inaction.

I was told that although the request to investigate the Roswell incident is unique, it still must be handled within

the normal methodology used by the GAO. This means that, at least initially, what the GAO cannot do is what those of us interested in Roswell would prefer: investigate the incident and find out what happened. The GAO does not, as a matter of course, investigate specific incidents in any subject. Accordingly, as Richard Davis, the Director of the National Security Analysis group at the GAO, wrote in a letter of February 9, 1994, to William J. Perry, Secretary of Defense, the GAO "is initiating a review of DOD's policies and procedures for acquiring, classifying, retaining, and disposing

of official government documents dealing with weather balloon, aircraft, and similar crash incidents." In the course of this review, the GAO will test whether various military agencies have "followed the proper procedures to ensure government accountability over such records."

This is probably not the type of investigation that everyone thought it might be when the headline "GAO to Investigate Roswell Crash" appeared in print. It is important to understand the limitations under which the GAO works as well as the necessity to conduct an inquiry like this in well-defined stages. There is no money

trail to follow, except perhaps the hints that Mac Brazel—the civilian who found some of the debris—received money as a bribe to keep quiet, so GAO methodology dictates that its investigation focus on a sample of incidents similar to Roswell (and including Roswell) to see whether the government followed proper procedures in the creation and retention of official documents about those events. This is understandable, but the bottom line is still that the GAO is not investigating the Roswell incident as such.

The investigation's focus is on documents for, I suspect, at least three reasons. Rep. Schiff has been attempting to find an answer to what happened at Roswell, one that can be supported by documentation, not blanket denials or with reference to a debunking statement by General Roger Ramey at Fort Worth in 1947 that itself cannot be substantiated with official records. Second, the GAO customarily does a great deal of its work, particularly in the preliminary stages of an investigation, by reviewing what documents reveal about government practices and actions. And third, the problem with Roswell for skeptic and proponent alike is that there are no known documents in government files that mention the case, so a logical first step is to try to locate such documents, if they exist.



Mark Rodeghier

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HYPNOSIS AND THE HILL

ABDUCTION CASE

BY MARK RODEGHIER

The Betty and Barney Hill abduction case has been exhaustively described and analyzed since it was first publicized in the mid-1960s. Although it was not the first abduction case investigated (that honor goes to the Villas-Boas case in Brazil by a few years), it is the first documented American case and the first abduction report to receive widespread publicity, in large part because of the book *The Interrupted Journey* by John Fuller. It was the prototype case for the abduction experience and included such components as physical examinations of the witnesses, about two hours of missing time, hypnotic regression to retrieve lost memories, and strange dreams afterwards that plagued Betty Hill and involved unearthly creatures.

Although it might seem that nothing useful can now be said or learned about the case, documents I have recently reviewed in the original National Investigations Committee on Aerial Phenomena (NICAP) case file contain details that should be placed in the historical record. CUFOS obtained the NICAP files in the early 1980s, and we have found them to be a crucial source of information for early UFO cases, events, and personalities. The information presented in this article is further evidence of the importance of maintaining and safekeeping UFO documents. The preservation and archiving of documents is now one of CUFOS' most important missions.

In the course of doing research with abductees, I have been motivated to review primary documents for several well-known abduction cases, the Hill case among them. I've also read many authors' accounts of the Hills' experiences in various books and articles. In the course of this review I've discovered a previously unreported detail of the Hills' original account that concerns who first raised the issue of hypnosis to retrieve their lost memories. As such it is a potentially important fact whose implication is worth exploring and, if nothing else, this detail should be placed in the public record.

Mark Rodeghier, Scientific Director of the Center for UFO Studies, works as a consultant in statistics and survey research methodology. He has written extensively on vehicle interference cases, abduction reports and abductees, and the Roswell event.

MISSING TIME

One of the most notable characteristics of the Hill investigation is that hypnosis was required to uncover the recollections of Barney and Betty concerning the events of the early morning hours of September 20, 1961. Although not every abduction witness needs to be hypnotized to aid in memory recall—in my own work, about one-fifth of the abductees recall many details without hypnosis—many do so require, and the treatment of the Hills with hypnosis by Dr. Benjamin Simon set the stage for its use in later abduction investigations.

Before discussing hypnosis in the Hill case further, a brief discussion about the missing time will be helpful to put things in perspective. A close reading of various accounts of the Hill case reveals discrepancies in how the matter of the missing two hours was discovered. In his recent book *Angels and Aliens*, Keith Thompson says: "While talking with civilian investigators one month after the incident, the Hills realized that the trip . . . had taken two hours longer than it should have." But in her book *Abductions*, Jenny Randles writes: "On arrival home, a discrepancy appeared in their timing: the journey had taken a couple of hours longer than it should have." And in some books, such as Phil Klass's *UFO-Abductions: A Dangerous Game*, it is unclear just when the missing hours were noticed. Klass says that two NICAP investigators "raised the possibility that, if Betty's nightmares were based on reality, this could explain the two hours of 'missing time,'" but he doesn't specify when the time gap became apparent.

The best source for locating the earliest mention of the missing time is the NICAP case file, specifically Walter Webb's initial report, dated October 26, 1961. There is no mention of missing time therein, but Webb does note the memory blackout that Barney had when he was watching the UFO through binoculars. To quote Webb:

In his conversation with me (and with his wife since the sighting) a mental block occurred when he mentioned the "leader" peering out the window at him. Mr. Hill believes he saw something he doesn't want to remember. . . . However, it is my view that the observer's blackout is not of any great significance. I think the

Portsmouth, N. H.
September 26, 1961

Dear Mr. Keyhoe:

The purpose of this letter is twofold. We wish to inquire if you have written any more books about unidentified flying objects since The Flying Saucer Conspiracy was published. If so, it would certainly be appreciated if you would send us the name of the publisher as we have been unsuccessful in finding any information more upto date than this book. A stamped self-addressed envelope is being included for your convenience.

My husband and I have become immensely interested in this topic, as we recently had quite a frightening experience, which does seem to differ from others of which we are aware. About midnight on September 20th, we were driving in a National Forest area in the White Mountains, in N. H. This is a desolate, uninhabited area. At first we noticed a bright object in the sky which seemed to be moving rapidly. We stopped our car and got out to observe it more closely with our binoculars. Suddenly it reversed its flight from the north to the southwest and appeared to be flying in a very erratic pattern. As we continued driving and then stopping to watch it, we observed the following flight pattern 777.

The object was spinning and appeared to be lighted only on one side which gave it a twinkling effect.

At it approached our car, we stopped again. As it hovered in the air in front of us, it appeared to be pancake in shape, ringed with windows in the front through which we could see bright blue-white lights. Suddenly two red lights appeared on each side. By this time my husband was standing in the road, watching closely. He saw wings protrude on each side and the red lights were on the wing tips.

As it glided closer he was able to see inside this object, but not too closely. He did see many figures scurrying about as though they were making some hurried type of preparation. One figure was observing us from the windows. From the distance, this was seen, the figures appeared to be about the size of a pencil, and seemed to be dressed in some type of shiny black uniform.

At this point, my husband became shocked and got back in the car, in a hysterical condition, laughing and repeating that they were going to capture us. He started driving the car - the motor had been left running. As we started to move, we heard several buzzing or beeping sounds which seemed to be striking the trunk of our car.

We did not observe this object leaving, but we did not see it again, although about thirty miles further south we were again bombarded by these same beeping sounds.

The next day we did make a report to an Air Force officer, who seemed to be very interested in the wings and red lights. We did not report my husband's observation of the interior as it seems too fantastic to be true.

At this time we are searching for any clue that might be helpful to my husband, in recalling whatever it was he saw that caused him to panic. His mind has completely blacked out at this point. Every attempt to recall, leaves him very frightened. We are considering the possibility of a competent psychiatrist who uses hypnotism.

This flying object was at least as large as a four motor plane, its flight was noiseless, and the lighting from the interior did not reflect on the grounds. There doesnot appear to be any damage to our car from the beeping sounds.

We both have been quite frightened by this experience, but fascinated. We feel a compelling urge to return to the spot where this occurred in the hope that we may again come in contact with this object. We realize this possibility is slight and we should, however, have more recent information regarding developments in the last six years.

Any suggested readings would be greatly appreciated. Your book has been of great help to us and a reassurance that we are not the only ones to have undergone an interesting and informative experience.

Very truly yours,

Mrs. Barney Hill

(Mrs.) Barney Hill

*Betty Hill's original
letter to NICAP,
written six days after
the experience.*

whole experience was so improbable and fantastic to the witness—along with the very real fear of being captured added to imagined fears—that his mind finally refused to believe what his eyes were perceiving and a mental block resulted.

Webb can certainly be excused for minimizing the importance of the blackout in 1961 (he did say, in a final report written four years later, that “In 1961, I did not attach much significance to Barney’s block. Now, I am not so sure”).

John Fuller, who conducted extensive interviews with the Hills, says that, after they arrived home that eventful morning, “the kitchen clock read shortly after five in the morning. ‘It looks,’ said Barney, ‘like we’ve arrived home a little later than expected.’” If true, then the Hills noticed almost immediately the period of missing time. In a letter dated April 2, 1990, to investigator Barbara Becker, Betty wrote that “At home, Barney’s first remark was ‘It is 5 o’clock, we should have been home by 3 a.m. at the latest.’” In this same letter, talking about a meeting on November 25, 1961, with Hohman and Jackson, two engineers interested in the Hill’s experience, Betty writes, “There had to be an explanation [for why the trip took so long]. Later this was called a missing time period. But right from the beginning Barney and I knew the trip home was much longer then it should have been.”

HYPNOSIS

Deciding when the Hills became aware of the missing time is crucial to understanding the letter that Betty wrote to Donald E. Keyhoe, director of NICAP, on September 26, six days after the event, but before she began to have dreams about the incident. This letter is of historical significance in ufology because, despite what has been written before about when hypnosis was suggested to the Hills, Betty Hill brought up the subject of hypnosis herself in the letter!

Published accounts of when and how hypnosis was suggested vary, but John Fuller’s book has always been assumed to be the most authoritative source. He states (pp. 47–48) that Major James MacDonald, a former intelligence officer in the Air Force who was an acquaintance of the Hills, was the first to suggest medical hypnosis during the interview of November 25, 1961. This suggestion arose later in the interview, after Barney was flabbergasted to realize “for the first time that at the rate of speed I always travel, we should have arrived home at least two hours earlier than we did.” Given Betty’s testimony in her letter to Becker, plus the intense scrutiny given to their experience by the Hills immediately afterwards, it is rather hard to believe that Barney or Betty did not recognize how much time was missing until two months later.

This might seem a trivial point on which to correct Fuller, but his accuracy (and honesty) are called into great

doubt by his account that the suggestion for hypnosis came from MacDonald. When Fuller published Betty’s letter to Keyhoe (pp. 30–31), he did not print the letter as written, but instead removed one critical sentence. As printed, the seventh paragraph reads:

At this time we are searching for any clue that might be helpful to my husband, in recalling whatever it was he saw that caused him to panic. His mind has completely blacked out at this point. Every attempt to recall leaves him very frightened. This flying object was at least as large as a four-motor plane, its flight was noiseless and the lighting of the interior did not reflect on the ground. There does not appear to be any damage to our car from the beeping sounds.

Notice how the fourth sentence doesn’t really follow from the third? The reason is because Fuller deleted a critical sentence. The seventh paragraph actually read (with the critical sentence in italics):

At this time we are searching for any clue that might be helpful to my husband, in recalling whatever it was he saw that caused him to panic. His mind has completely blacked out at this point. Every attempt to recall leaves him very frightened. *We are considering the possibility of a competent psychiatrist who uses hypnotism.*

Why did Fuller remove the last sentence from the letter? Unfortunately, he is now dead and can’t be interviewed. Nevertheless, I can suggest the following motive. Fuller was an accomplished writer, and a rereading of *The Interrupted Journey* demonstrates that it remains one of the best-written UFO books in history. As a good writer, Fuller was aware of the need for dramatic development and key events around which to structure a story (though one would suppose that a couple abducted by alien beings is drama enough). Dramatic structure, which builds toward the hypnosis in the book—the hypnotic transcripts and their discussion occupy the majority of the text—requires that the idea of hypnosis not be introduced too early, nor the emphasis on missing time. To accomplish this, Fuller had to delete the reference to hypnotism in Betty’s first letter, and he had to write that the Hills only fully realized their missing time some two months later.

Even if my interpretation of Fuller’s motive is inaccurate, the essential point is that the Hills themselves suggested hypnosis, before any contact with investigators. Barney did have a mental block, as mentioned in the letter, but why would Betty suggest hypnosis? It certainly had never been used in UFO investigations previously. I wrote to Betty recently about this very point, and here is her reply:

As for hypnosis, you ask what knowledge I had about

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BIG (SPACE) BROTHERS

BY JEROME CLARK

John E. Mack, *Abduction: Human Encounters with Aliens*. New York: Charles Scribner's Sons, April 1994. 432p.

You have a sensitivity. . . . You pick up on things. You can talk to the earth. The earth talks to you. . . . Listen to the earth. . . . You can hear the anguish of the spirits. You can hear the wailing cries of the imbalances. It will save you."

Who is speaking here? No, not the well-tanned host of a New Age infomercial. No, not some wacky tree-hugger. No, not one of Orfeo Angelucci's space pals, though you're getting warmer, no doubt because at some point in your life you read either Chapter Two of Angelucci's *The Secret of the Saucers* (1955) or Carl Jung's discussion of same in the epilogue to *Flying Saucers: A Modern Myth of Things Seen in the Skies* (1959).

No, the communicator of the above-articulated twaddle is an alien named "Ohgeeka" or "Ageeka," planet or dimension of origin unspecified, in the newly published *Abduction*. The author, psychiatrist and *IUR* contributor ("Helping Abductees," July/August 1992) John E. Mack, is—as most of you know by now—a Pulitzer Prize-winning psychobiographer (of T. E. Lawrence) and a professor at the Cambridge Hospital, Harvard Medical School. He is friends with many of America's brightest intellectual lights. He is also a friend of Carl Sagan. He is, from all indications including my own limited experience with him, a genuinely nice man. He is also a brave one. UFO research, not for the faint of heart under the best of circumstances, is in Mack's circles an all-but-unimaginable act of intellectual defiance.

For these reasons and others, not the least of them its publisher's fat promotional budget, *Abduction* may be destined to become the most widely read UFO book since 1987's *Communion*, with which it has much in common, even down to rectal probes. Mack subscribes to at least one of Whitley Strieber's views of the abduction phenomenon (about which Strieber has entertained, at one time or another, virtually every view it is possible for a single representative of *Homo sapiens* to entertain): that abduction-generated terror and trauma are initiatory ordeals at the other side of which one learns that the aliens are sensitive New Age dudes. Ohgeeka/Ageeka would feel comfortable in the company of Angelucci's ETs, who were given to saying

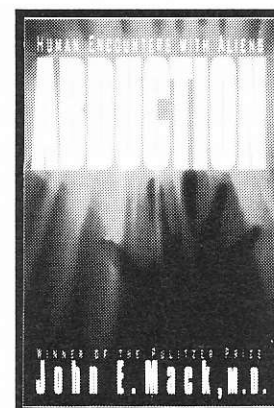
things like, "Weep, Orfeo. Let tears unblind your eyes. For at this moment we weep with you for Earth and her Children. For all its apparent beauty Earth is a purgatorial world among the planets evolving intelligent life. Hate, selfishness and cruelty rise from many parts of it like a dark mist."

ACTING WITH GOD

To one of my tastes a little of this goes a long way. Yet such misanthropy—which is what it amounts to—has had a enduring appeal both to contactee-oriented saucerians and to ufologists (Donald Keyhoe and Stanton Friedman, for two prominent examples) who have rejected contactees but embraced their message: human race bad, alien visitors good. If they do nothing else (and in my opinion they do do nothing else), these notions supply aid and comfort to critics who contend that scientific pretensions notwithstanding, UFO research is at its core a religious quest. Stated this baldly, the claim misrepresents what UFO research is about; worse, it is often employed as a rhetorical strategy which enables critics to dodge the real scientific questions UFO research raises. Still, the charge is true enough in some specific cases.

Such as John Mack's. Here no extrapolation whatever is necessary. You can find it in black and white, in one form or another, on just about every page. Take page 200: "If, in fact, the alien beings are closer to the divine source or *anima mundi* than human beings generally seem to be, then it is possible that their presence among us, however cruel and traumatic in some instances, may be part of a larger process that is bringing us back to God." On page 329 Mack quotes approvingly an abductee's assertion that the aliens are "acting with God." The 13 abductees whose stories comprise the bulk of this long book tell how that is supposed to be happening.

Much of what we read here is the familiar abduction phenomenon documented by Thomas E. Bullard, Budd Hopkins, David M. Jacobs, and, in recent months, MUFON's abduction-transcription project (*MUFON UFO Journal*, February and March issues). Much of the rest of it is unique, or so it seems at first reflection, only in its prominence. In his



Jerome Clark is editor of IUR and vice president of CUFOs. His most recent book is Unexplained! (1993).

massive 1987 survey of more than 300 abduction narratives through 1985, Bullard took note of an aspect he called "theophany," characterizing it as the "strangest and rarest episode in abduction reports"; in such encounters experiencers confront "seemingly divine powers." He found only six instances, and—as was not the case in other aspects of abduction experience—few common elements among them.

It is Kenneth Ring's *The Omega Project* (1992) that *Abduction* most resembles, at least in the overall conclusions it draws. Both books are broadly speculative, but Ring's at least begins with empirical data compiled from psychological testing of those he calls "UFO experiencers" (UFOers), including abductees, and it convincingly eliminates mundane explanations (such as fantasy-proneness) before launching into a less convincing attempt to link UFO and other anomalous experiences (primarily of the near-death variety) with planetary consciousness expansion. Mack gives alternative explanations hardly more than a sidelong glance. Nonetheless both his abductees and Ring's anomaly-experiencers report an enhanced spiritual and ecological awareness.

Yet in Ring's book case histories appear only spottily, and nearly always in fragments, so it is not clear how many of these are really "abductions" as ordinarily understood or other kinds of experiences, such as those associated with contactees. Most ufologists have tended to treat abductions as a separate category of experience from that claimed by contactees, for the same reason preabduction-era ufologists saw CE3s as fundamentally different from contact stories. Whereas CE3 witnesses reported little communication, seemed genuinely troubled by the encounter, did not seek publicity, and generally had the social profile of other kinds of UFO witnesses, contactees actively sought meetings with angelic extraterrestrials, often had personal histories in occultism (and sometimes confidence crime), and all too keenly lusted after publicity and profit. There was nothing to link contactees with UFOs as such. For them UFOs only provided a pop-culture cover for a mystical vision or a money-making scheme. To most modern ufologists abductions have seemed more a variety of CE3 than a latter-day contact claim. Betty Hill, after all, is no George Adamski.

EVIDENCE ABSENCE

But consider these words from Isabel Davis's classic essay "Meet the Extraterrestrial" (*Fantastic Universe*, November 1957), in which she outlined the difference between occupant reports (as CE3s were then called) and contact claims: In the former, Davis observed, the aliens "never *communicate* at all. They utter no lofty messages, no explanations of ancient riddles, no admonitions, warnings, reassurances, prophecies, or esoteric doctrine."

Mack's abduction humanoids do virtually all of the above. His cases fuse themes from CE3s (not-human entities doing not-human things) and contact claims (benevolent

New Age aliens working to save earth and earthlings). From simply a narrative point of view, Mack's accounts aren't nearly so boring as the latter, but they are less credible than the former. The best-documented CE3s (Valensole, Socorro, Kelly-Hopkinsville, Boianai) cause us to think anomalous *events* of some kind occurred, whereas Mack's informants, the sincerity of all of whom I am prepared to grant, are telling wild and fantastic stories of the sort I think of as *experience anomalies*—tales of extraordinary encounters which, if literally interpreted, would require us to reinvent the world; yet even as they resist conventional accounting, they exist only as memory and testimony. They may be authentic in some sense, but that does not necessarily make them valid.

In other words, to say that ordinary explanations fail—and so far all proposed counterexplanations have indeed failed—ought not therefore to give us free rein to reach for the most extreme possible conclusions. Nonetheless Mack here demands as our response to these tales nothing less than the wholesale rejection of the "Western scientific/materialist world," an entity Mack, who possesses some remarkable political opinions (about which more shortly), does not like very much. He asks us to overturn the world as we know it because some people tell bizarre yet curiously consistent stories, mostly under hypnosis, and exhibit a marked degree of stress as they do so. They may suffer, too, from permanent trauma for which there appears no other cause than the one alleged: terrifying, intrusive encounters with otherworldly beings.

These considerations surely are sufficient to justify further investigation but at this juncture not much more. And when some of these same individuals erupt into past-life memories (or, in one instance, "recall" being at the site of a Roswell-like UFO crash), the question is not whether con-fabulation is going on but how much.

There is some evidence here that something is going on beyond hypnotically induced fantasy: a body of consciously recalled testimony, a handful of independently observed UFO sightings which apparently correlate with claimed abductions, a few abduction episodes in which more than one witness figures. But Mack makes little of these and shows only modest interest in investigative efforts that require more than interaction with abductees in his home or office, and so these crucial issues, which touch on the basic question of whether anything really *happened*, pass in and out of the text so quickly that the inattentive reader risks missing them.

As to other kinds of more direct evidence, Mack writes complacently (p. 41), "The physical phenomena that accompany abductions are important, but gain their significance primarily in that they corroborate the experiences themselves; for the effects tend to be subtle and would not by themselves convince a Western-trained clinician of their meaning. For example, even though the abductees are certain that the cuts, scars, scoop marks, and small fresh ulcers . . . are related to the physical procedures performed on the

ships, these lesions are too trivial by themselves to be medically significant. Similarly, abductees will often experience that they have been pregnant and have had the pregnancy removed during an abduction, but there is not yet a case where a physician has documented that a fetus has disappeared in relation to an abduction." Analyses of alleged implants recovered from a small number of abductees reveal nothing out of the ordinary.

Right or wrong, one immediately obvious explanation for the absence of significant physical evidence is that abductions are not physical events but imagined ones. Mack, however, holds forth for a far more extraordinary answer: To hope for conclusive physical evidence, he says (p. 43), "may even be a sort of 'error of logical types.' In other words it may be wrong to expect that a phenomenon whose very nature is subtle, and one of whose purposes may be to stretch and expand our ways of knowing beyond the purely materialist approaches of Western science, will yield its secrets to an epistemology or methodology that operates at a lower level of consciousness."

I suppose this could be true, but I wouldn't count on it. To start with, it starts on a slippery slope. From it one could plead for just about anything, including—a cynic might have it—the existence of the celebrated immaterial being named Santa Claus. All one has to do is what Mack does here: assume that absence of evidence is not evidence of absence. The assumption undercuts just about any hope for rational inquiry and understanding. Moreover, where the larger UFO phenomenon is concerned, it is demonstrably false. The open literature—not to mention whatever classified technical reports there may be on the Roswell debris—provides us with a body of impressive evidence bolstering the hypothesis that UFOs are physical and extraordinarily anomalous. Physical-trace and radar/visual cases are eminently investigable and documentable via the methodology of Western science.

In fact, as I have remarked elsewhere, ufologists pay heed to the abduction phenomenon precisely because of its ostensible relationship to the UFO phenomenon of CE2s, instrumented observations, photographs, multiple witnesses, and trained observers. On its own the abduction evidence is thin stuff, intriguing but inconclusive, resistant so far to conventional psychiatric diagnosis but compromised by its association with hypnosis—and now by the murky controversies over false memories, Satanic ritual abuse (SRA), and the like. Mack does not touch on these latter at all, not even long enough to deny, even perfunctorily, their relevance to the abduction question. Yet as both abductees and SRA "victims" come in droves out of the woodwork, both claiming repressed memories in support of whose veridicality we have only ambiguous supporting evidence (if that), a lot of sober reflection seems in order.

What *Abduction* gives us instead is a good dose of Mack's peculiar political beliefs, which one in due course suspects affect not only his interpretation of the abduction

question but his abductees' as well. Worse, one fears that they influence the abductees' sense of what they experienced. The aliens Mack finds, in other words, turn out to be the aliens Mack was looking for.

These are not the alien abductors of whom Jacobs wrote in *Secret Life* (1992, p. 233): "They express no interest in [the abductee's] personal, social, or family relationships, except as they bear on the breeding program [the creation of alien/human hybrids]. They express no interest in politics, culture, economics, or the rich and extraordinarily complex tapestry that makes up human relationships and societies. They do not ask even idle questions about this. They do, however, express interest in birth control, smoking, and health problems that might directly relate to childbearing for women." From his own group of abductees, Jacobs would conclude that the abductors have the same relationship to abductees that laboratory technicians have to white rats. Whatever courtesy or kindness they exhibit is simply to alleviate abductees' fears and thus render them easier to manipulate.

Jacobs's humanoids are recognizable cousins of the humanoids of traditional CE3 lore. Mack's come out of the contactee universe. They may be rougher in their methods than Adamski's Space Brothers, but they are Space Brothers nonetheless, albeit with updated and more fashionable concerns: pollution this time, not atomic bombs. Abductees suffer terror, intense physical pain sometimes bordering on torture, disrupted lives, anxiety, depression, anger, sexual violation and attendant dysfunction, unsought pregnancies, and other miseries—but all that's okay, according to Mack, because in the end these indignities are for the ultimate benefit of individual abductees and the whole darned human race, which direly needs to be saved from . . . well, you'll never guess.

CURE OR DISEASE?

I have met Mack once in my life, at a conference in Santa Barbara, California, in November 1990. Though we talked about UFOs and abductions, I remember practically nothing of what either of us had to say on those subjects. I do, however, recall a conversation on another matter of mutual interest, politics and world affairs. In the course of that conversation, I understood Mack to say that anti-Communism is a form of racism.

I eventually decided I could not have heard him right. Otherwise I would have been forced to conclude he subscribed to an opinion so preposterous that only a Harvard professor could hold it. The rise of totalitarianism in our century is one of the great tragedies of all human history. Under Communism (in particular during the murderous regimes of Stalin, Mao, and Pol Pot) tens of millions of human beings were killed, and those who managed to survive under it lived—and live, in those places Communism survives, merely temporarily one hopes—in con-

trolled, oppressive circumstances. *Not* to oppose such evil seems to me, as a democrat, a liberal, and a child of the Enlightenment, at the very least an act of shocking moral obtuseness.

My three-plus-year-old conversation with Mack came back to me as I was reading *Abduction*, which is loaded with hand-wringing pronouncements on humanity's failings versus the aliens' superior moral wisdom. There is no question about what Mack regards as the supreme evil of our era, and it is not totalitarianism, which is not once mentioned. On page 10, introducing a theme to which he continually returns, Mack remarks, "UFO abductions have been reported and collected most frequently in Western countries or countries dominated by Western culture and values. Insofar as the abduction phenomenon may be seen as occurring in the context of the global ecological crisis, which is an outcome of the Western materialist/dualistic worldview, it may be that its 'medicine' is being administered primarily where it is most needed—in the United States and the other Western industrial countries."

All non-Western cultures are treated with appropriate piety. Unlike the planet-plunderers of the Western-European tradition, American Indians are "close to the earth," according to an alien (p. 287; these words are supposed to have been uttered in the course of a UFO encounter *which occurred in a past life*). Tibetan lamas and their Buddhist beliefs show up here and there in the text, always in a context that depicts them as victims of Western arrogance and ignorance, never—as in the unblinkered truth—victims of a brutal Chinese Communist occupation which threatens their culture far more gravely than any amount of Western apathy ever could. Mack's selective telling of this sorry tale has led my friend and MUFON UFO Journal editor Dennis Stacy to speculate that maybe Mack thinks the "rape of Tibet by the Chinese was actually led by a secret cabal of corporate capitalists."

If the aliens indeed are here to save the earth from environmental apocalypse, they ought to direct their attention elsewhere. It is not much needed in the West, where environmentalism flourishes and plays a large role in public and private decision-making about air, water, and land use, species preservation, and technological development. Protection of nature has become as much a Western value as capitalism and democracy. The world's most egregious ecological horrors are to be found in the nations and republics of the former Soviet empire and in the Third World (for a disturbing account of what is happening to the ecology—and thus to the people—of Africa, read Robert D. Kaplan's "The Coming Anarchy" in *The Atlantic Monthly*, February 1994). In Third World states environmentalists are often themselves an endangered species, harassed and on occasion even murdered by governments or powerful private interests more concerned with unrestrained exploitation than protection of natural resources.

In any event, whatever else Mack would have you

believe, pollution is a consequence of industrialization, not of capitalism. In the modern world, nations with free markets have, on the whole, the cleanest environmental records. Maybe Mack's aliens just aren't doing their homework.

Throughout the book one reads accounts of appalling abuse of human beings, including children, by alleged aliens. These accounts are followed by the abductees' expression of love for, and even identification with, their tormentors. Some even fantasize they themselves are aliens; those who cannot make that imaginative leap content themselves with the conviction that they are conduits through whom the aliens' message will spread to those of us who have been blinded by the Enlightenment. Mack approves wholly, even hinting that he may be a part of the big cosmic game plan.

Mack believes that you can't make an omelette without breaking eggs. If one rejects the values of the Western tradition, one can excuse the conduct of an all-powerful state, or an all-powerful alien intelligence, which cannot be troubled to treat human beings with decent regard. Cruelty counts as mere detail when the end is noble—as, of course, tyrants and terrorists always say it is and sometimes even believe it is. Those victims who embrace their tormentors bring to mind the protagonist of Orwell's *1984*; after prolonged torture and overwhelming psychological assault, he decided he "loved Big Brother." Is it any wonder that Mack's abductees love their Space Brothers?

One may agree or disagree with Jacobs and Hopkins on whether abduction experiences represent real-life interactions with extraterrestrials. But one never doubts where their sympathies lie: firmly on the side that favors the dignity of individual human beings. Their outrage is focused where it belongs. Mack's focus, on the other hand, is severely blurred.

The ontological status of abduction experiences is yet undetermined, of course. Whatever else it may accomplish, Mack's book should serve to remind us that it is dangerous to entertain "too much ambition in our search for answers," as Bullard once remarked of abduction research generally. "We are often better off settling for small, obtainable answers along the way toward that big but distant one."

Serious abduction study is in its infancy. Let us let it grow up. In the meantime, let it be said that the aliens Mack would have us follow look not just unbelievable but undeserving of belief. One wishes profoundly for their nonexistence or, barring that, their absence. ♦

New Stringfield Status Report

Veteran UFO researcher Leonard H. Stringfield has produced his *seventh* Status Report on UFO crash/retrievals, featuring new information that surfaced in 1993. Published in February 1994 and entitled *UFO Crash/Retrievals: Search for Proof in a Hall of Mirrors*, the 67-page monograph may be ordered for \$16.50 from The Center for UFO Studies, 2457 W. Peterson, Chicago, IL 60659.

MISSING SCIENCE

BY THOMAS E. BULLARD

Robert A. Baker and Joe Nickell, *Missing Pieces: How to Investigate Ghosts, UFOs, Psychics, and Other Mysteries*. Buffalo, N.Y.: Prometheus Books, 1992. 339p.

Ufologists need all the help they can get in the difficult art of investigation, even when that help comes from an unexpected source. Any publication from Prometheus Books and authored by enthusiastic CSICOP members Robert A. Baker and Joe Nickell would seem like a poor bet for constructive advice, but *Missing Pieces* is a surprising book. Its authors call it a practical manual for the investigation of ghosts, UFOs, psychics, and various other paranormal mysteries, and the book lives up to its billing. I now believe in miracles, though I am sure the authors would disapprove.

The first of the book's three sections is a primer in the theory and practice of investigation, the second applies those principles to specific paranormal claims, while the third gives down-to-earth counsel for handling opponents and the media. Sections one and three offer the most useful insights. The middle section, though shot through with astute exposés and delightful anecdotes, sets a bad example when it illustrates the errors an investigator ought to avoid by committing them in cold blood. These errors are never more obvious than in the authors' rough handling of UFOs, and especially abductions.

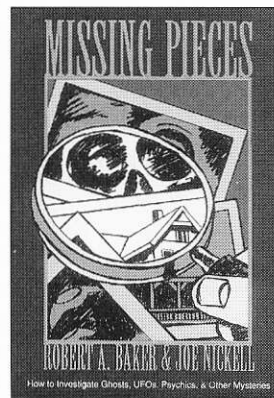
Its faults aside, the book repays close study for its lucid treatment of methodology. Baker is a psychologist and Nickell a private detective, both of them prepared by professional training and extensive experience to mount a formidable assault on paranormal claims. The reader learns practice as well as principles when the authors describe how they apply various techniques to a case, and how those techniques work to uncover the hoax or error that creates an illusion of mystery. A book that summarizes so much good sense in a systematic manner complements existing guidebooks such as Allan Hendry's *The UFO Handbook* and the MUFON investigation manual, and deserves a place in the training of every ufologist. Of course every conclusion is negative, but this fact should not deter ufologists from hearing out these well-qualified investigators and learning the skills they teach, despite a sharp parting of the ways on conclusions.

The authors approach a paranormal claim as a puzzle

with missing pieces. This puzzle has a conventional solution, but not necessarily a simplistic one. The adherents may be true believers impervious to reason, but they may also be confused or deceived and open to a reasonable answer. Unlike some skeptics, the authors feel those adherents deserve a rational answer that is also persuasive and respectful—in other words the skeptic must build a case to convince the adherent, or at least a curious and sometimes credulous public, and not just preach to the choir of fellow skeptics.

How to fill this rather tall order requires a broad approach. It demands an understanding of the background of the claim, an investigation of the evidence at hand, and a philosophy of interpretation to read the clues in a rational way. The background any investigator must keep in mind is that beliefs do not exist in a vacuum. A believer believes out of complex needs for understanding, novelty, social standing, and a relationship with the transcendent. Human motivations like a desire to belong and a need for self-esteem often exert more influence on beliefs than observation. Eyewitness testimony is unreliable, memory pliant, and the will to believe often distorts the facts into honest but profound error, while expectations and wishes pack the power to reshape observation from top to bottom. The investigator must suspect that truth is an unlikely survivor in any paranormal claim.

Other essential pieces of background understanding story, tenets, and literature of paranormal claims. Knowing who influences a believer can win half the battle. Where do psi abilities come from, for example? The authors list various systems and beliefs supposed to elicit or enhance these abilities so an investigator can recognize where adherents get their ideas. A history of these beliefs serves the same preparatory purpose, since old errors never die but simply return in new disguises. And we must remember the media. Their complicity in the propagation and perpetuation of uncritical, sensationalistic notions is largely responsible for the thriving culture of pseudoscientific beliefs today. Any wild claim deserves an airing, any refutation or disclaimer rarely rates a passing mention. Investigators taking a critical stance must keep a close watch on the media as the most



Thomas E. Bullard, Ph.D., a folklorist, is a member of the CUFOS Board of Directors.

damaging and irresponsible influence of all.

A few basic skills prepare the investigator to deal with claims of believers or people misled by beliefs. At the top of the list comes a scientific attitude—a dedication to empiricism and causation, a preference for parsimonious solutions and a choice of scientific over superstitious explanations, and a willingness to suspend judgment and change opinions according to the evidence, rather than change evidence to accord with opinion. Nothing is more important than this scientific mindset. Add to it a mastery of such practical skills as interviewing techniques, the tricks of the deceptive, photography and recording operations, and the investigator sets off well-armed and armored to confront the paranormal.

As rich as the book may be with techniques, it keeps sight of broad strategies and goals without getting lost in minutiae. A practical strategy for investigation should start with fact-finding. Get behind the story as it appears in witness testimony or the media and the facts may quickly belie the claims, as happens when a check of celestial positions reveals that a UFO coincides with the location of Venus. Once familiar with the claim and convinced that it is more than simple hoax or distortion, the investigator may propose a hypothetical explanation and test it. Any chance that the Nazca lines of Peru laid out a landing field for spaceships vanished when experimenters discovered that simple methods available to prehistoric people were adequate to expand a small model into full-scale figures. Cases previously solved and bearing similarities to the case at hand may offer valuable clues, while experts with special knowledge may have the knowhow to crack a difficult case, if the investigator is perceptive enough to see where such expertise is useful. Here then is an admirably practical map into the murky landscape of claims mysterious.

These hard-headed principles of scientific and legal investigation prepare the practitioner with a sound philosophy. No right-thinking individual could deny its wisdom. Any quarrel with the authors lies with their practices, not their principles. The unfortunate fact is that the large mid-section of applied investigations leaves reasons aplenty to pick a fight. Baker and Nickell are at their most effective when a specific investigation resolves a single case. When the “Amityville Horror” proves a hoax or the ghosts in a haunted house turn out to be raccoons in the woodwork, readers can inspect the corpse and feel satisfied that the mystery is truly laid to rest. The authors demolish supernatural claims about the Shroud of Turin with a devastating volley of proofs, and leave ancient astronaut claims without a rational leg to stand on.

When reading the UFO chapter, I had to wonder if it belonged to the same book. Those high standards for quality of inquiry and the obligation to build a case on evidence instead of dogma suddenly disappeared, and I felt expelled from paradise into the land of the CSICOPs. The authors exchanged their incisive criticism for a broader, less focused treatment. They kept their distance from the subject and

settled for inferences, speculations, and unsubstantiated arguments, apparently forgetful that the standards of investigation are double-edged and govern the skeptic as well as the proponent. The litany of lapses speaks for itself.

Fortune favors the prepared mind, and we all hail the authors’ principle that investigators need a firm grasp on their subject. Yet the authors show a loose grip for simple facts about UFOs on several occasions. I somehow find myself listed as an “abduction guru” (p. 231), though at least “by far the most scholarly and sober” of them, by way of consolation. Budd Hopkins and other investigators who deal directly with abductees also have this appellation hung on them, but the consequent suggestion that I deal with abductees or lead anyone is contrary to fact. I just push data around, thank you. Then contactee Truman Bethurum becomes Bethrun (p. 200), Renaissance artist Piero della Francesca changes to Pierre, and author Desmond Leslie reverses his name to Leslie Desmond (p. 184), though he straightens himself out later and perhaps the blame belongs with the proofreader. Dime novels enjoyed a long run before World War I (p. 186).

A summary of the Barney and Betty Hill abduction case (p. 202) states that John Fuller did not emphasize Dr. Benjamin Simon’s conclusion that the experience was a fantasy, or mention in his book that two years elapsed between the sighting and therapy with Dr. Simon. I call attention to pages 86, 226–227, and 320 of *The Interrupted Journey* (Berkley Medallion Books, 1966) to show that Fuller makes quite explicit the chronology of events and the judgments of Dr. Simon. The authors also attribute Betty’s dreams to investigator influence and her readings of UFO literature, when in fact her dreams followed the encounter by ten days but investigators did not arrive until several weeks later. These errors are small matters, to be sure, but authorship is largely an act of faith. In this case the reader has to trust the investigator to master the subject and deal scrupulously with facts. Carelessness with small matters easily checked causes the reader to question whether the authors fumble larger and more obscure issues.

Another sign of carelessness appears in the brief discussion of the first UFO photograph from 1883 (p. 185). If the astronomer counted 300 mysterious dark objects crossing the sun and those objects turned out to be flying geese, we have to wonder how many geese were flying around that did not cross the face of the sun. The sun subtends an angle of one-half of one degree of the sky; if the rest of the sky received equal favor, they numbered 108,000—that’s geese, mind you, not starlings; and in August, a bit early for the migratory season. More bird troubles turn up in discussion of the Lubbock Lights (p. 189). Radar tracked objects at 13,000 feet traveling hundreds of miles per hour faster than any jet, yet later in the paragraph we learn that the photographs show light reflecting off flights of plovers. Not even Texans are likely to boast that their state was the home of supersonic plovers in 1951. The authors are guilty of logical

howlers, or else they cut too much connecting information to keep compatibility among statements in the same paragraph. Either way, these faults fall rudely on the ears of attentive readers, and undercut the case under construction.

The fault of oversimplification is also much in evidence. Whoever dismisses the airship reports of 1896–97 as journalistic hoaxes (p. 186) has not looked carefully into *those* claims. Far more of them were due to real observations of Venus or fire balloons than to whole-cloth fabrications. The media take primary responsibility for UFO waves in these pages, and while the media role is important, waves are less simple and straightforward than this explanation suggests. Richard Hall recalled (*Uninvited Guests*, p. 215) that the number of UFOs reported in the press by no means correlated with the number of reports received at the NICAP office. In one respect the role of the press is a truism—we do not know if a wave is underway unless reports circulate, and press reportage may create the illusion of a wave as well as provoke one. In a final verdict, we know too little about the intricate relationships between UFO waves and media treatment to value the shallow analysis of causation found here.

As zealously as the authors spread the gospel of scientific objectivity, they also sing the praises of the Condon Committee. Faith makes strange bedfellows. The practices of this committee fell a little short of an ideal scientific investigation, by about the distance between New York and California. True enough, the investigation had all the outer trappings of authority and the organization for a serious effort. Edward Condon was a respected scientist and deservedly so, the authors contributing to the report distinguished in their areas of expertise, the field investigations numerous and competent. So where's the problem? One shining example lies in case studies that uncover unknown or difficult to explain phenomena, while the conclusions reassure us that all is well, and seem transplanted from an entirely different study. If we take Baker and Nickell's advice, that "the best way to appreciate what the report does to the myth of the UFOs is to read it in its entirety," what we see is a hole in accountability where findings and conclusions just do not fit together.

A second problem is the attitude of Condon himself. He seems to have reached his conclusions before the study ever began, and made no secret that he expected a negative answer—and we know the power of expectations. The inner conflicts of the project are familiar and need no repetition here. The lesson they teach is that openmindedness, objectivity, and subservience of opinion to evidence are ideals of science that scientists do not always realize. Science is a human endeavor, its practitioners prone to human weaknesses. An earlier distinguished commission reached the foregone conclusion that the earth is stationary; nevertheless, it moves.

A good investigator weighs both sides of an issue, but the treatment of J. Allen Hynek in these pages is decidedly one-sided. He was a leading astronomer and a 20-year

consultant to the Air Force with access to a multitude of reports, before he went wrong and became a true believer. His conversion hangs oddly in the air, a thing without rhyme or reason for all we see here. Nowhere do we read of the possibility that he changed his mind in proper scientific fashion because the evidence persuaded him. As a proponent he was only an astronomer and failed to appreciate the psychological dimension of UFO reports (p. 195), but the authors express no such reservations about the authority of skeptical astronomers to pronounce on all matters. The authors see a telltale sign of pseudoscience when ufologists publish in their own literature instead of submitting to the review channels of established journals. Not mentioned is the difficulty Hynek had in publishing a mere letter, and no foaming-at-the-mouth piece of fanaticism either, in *Science* during 1966. It is hard to reason when you must remain silent. How do ufologists call attention to their subject—much less initiate a meaningful dialogue—if established science will not listen and they have no right to speak outside established channels? It's Catch-22 all over again.

The answer for abductions resorts to a scattergun blast of standard skeptical arguments. These stories are essentially psychological fantasies with content stored from media exposure and recovered as cryptomnesic memories, or confabulations created by true-believer hypnotists who cue and lead fantasy-prone subjects, or products of anomalistic psychology such as hallucinatory experience and screen memories for mundane traumas. Add hoaxers and pathological liars and not a possibility escapes unharmed. The authors do the readers a service by calling attention to the pliancy of human memory, the suggestibility of hypnotic subjects, and the perfectly natural occurrence of hallucination, vivid fantasy, or missing time. Where they go wrong is in pressing these truths to a conclusion the evidence does not warrant.

Skeptical inquiry into abductions ended before it began, the answers preceded the questions. This approach saves a great deal of time otherwise wasted on genuine investigations, but it also leads to some rather musty reading when skeptics resurrect long-buried arguments and present them as fresh findings. As usual, experiments with hypnotized non-abductees turn up as proof that anyone can tell an abduction story under hypnosis. Also as usual, no one worries if the experimenters led their subjects, or notices that every non-abductee described a different type of entity, unlike most real abductees. The authors accept these experiments at face value without asking any of the critical questions a good investigator should apply. Another vacation for the critical faculty begins when we read that memory is prone to failure, distortion, and fabrication, with or without hypnosis. Memory falls far short of a true and immutable tape recording of events as they really were, but this fact does not mean that all memory is false. Details lapse and skew, but details of what? Something had to happen to produce details in the first place. The fact that witnesses

describe a car crash in different ways does not forgo the need for the wrecker, the ambulance, and the road sweeper to do their work. The point that eyewitness testimony is far from perfect deserves attention, but so does a balanced distinction between variable details and the underlying event that makes them possible.

Fantasy is one potential source for an underlying experience, and the authors suspect a fantasy-prone personality lurking behind most abduction stories. Whether abductees are fantasy-prone is an empirical question with well-defined characteristics. Tests are possible, and test results are on record—for once we can dispute an abduction issue with substance and not just with air. The tests clearly belong in the forefront of any discussion, but the authors miss this opportunity. They cite an informal study that supports their hypothesis (p. 225), but not others, including Kenneth Ring's well-known book, *The Omega Project*, where most abductees flunk a specific fantasy-prone test with flying colors. The most specific inquiries make clear that abductees do not fit the clinical profile for this personality type. To be fair, Ring's book may have appeared after the authors' manuscript went to press, but his findings and others saw print as much as two years earlier. A little research could have replaced speculation with evidence. As the matter stands, so much emphasis on fantasy-proneness as a leading explanation looks as forlorn as a campaign poster for a losing candidate the morning after election day.

Good science and good investigation include testing hypotheses when possible, and recognizing anomalies when they occur. The authors' inquiry strikes out on both counts. More about abductions than fantasy-proneness lends itself to test, at least by the rudimentary means of comparison. It shows that details in the reports may differ, but a story of considerable length and elaborateness recurs from narrator to narrator with striking similarities in order and content. This consistency holds true among dozens of investigators despite their diverse personalities and techniques. These results affirm at least to some small degree a consistency that is a genuine property of abduction reports, and independent of external influences like hypnosis or the personality and expectations of an investigator. Here then is evidence rather than speculation, and it refutes key skeptical arguments. Conclusive evidence? Of course not, but a step in the right direction away from the speculative armchair—and a step not taken in this book.

As bearer of these sad comparative tidings, I become the butt of several oddly reasoned criticisms (pp. 231–32). My efforts would be more credible if I had used a better database less dependent on hearsay. Amen to that, but I used 104 detailed abduction reports from the literature as the best data available. I too would like something better, like direct observations and laboratory controls rather than verbal reports drawn from printed sources; I prefer to make use of what I have and learn as much as possible from it, than to draw conclusions without benefit of any data at all. If

abduction reports are necessarily hearsay and hearsay does not rate so much as a hearing, this book on how to investigate becomes a manual in how to avoid investigating. Nobody said abductions were easy. The data are certainly sloppy—but a challenge to resourcefulness rather than a cause for complacency or despair. Another complaint is that I find differences between the stories told by experimental non-abductees and “real” abductees, but “[fail] to consider that the narratives themselves are quite different,” one group originating with ordinary students, the other with experienced fantasizers. Just a few pages earlier the authors reassured us that the experimental subjects' narratives were practically indistinguishable from the real thing! Is inconsistency in the name of preconception now a virtue?

Speaking of preconceptions, “nothing he has said in his analysis contradicts the fact that all of the contactees and abductees are, more than likely, either fantasy-prone or perpetrators of a hoax.” These are revealing words. Without benefit of comparative studies or psychological tests, without so much as interviews with a sizable number of abductees (or even one?), the authors promote the fantasy-prone and hoax hypotheses to the status of almost certain facts. How much could I say to contradict a fact? But here the authors skip a few steps in due process and recognize a fact where the rest of us see only a supposition. The best way to root out fantasy and fakery is by digging at the source, through direct investigation of the abductee. Lacking the opportunity for this approach, the indirect route is open where hoax and fantasy leave behind their tracks in the narrative texts. Surely reliable reports should vary as much as unreliable ones if all the stories are fictitious, and surely hypnosis should promote better fantasy than unassisted recall. Both predictions failed in comparative tests. These are the real facts, at least the only facts we have, and they speak for themselves to contradict the fantasy and hoax hypotheses.

Other lines of evidence lead in the same direction. The authors allege (p. 223) that people claiming an abduction would tell essentially the same story, even down to the details and dialogue. This argument is a convenient way to deal with similarities in abduction reports, but a peculiar assumption both at face value and in relation to some of the authors' own arguments. Similar stories seem to contradict the supposed influence of the media on storytellers. Media influences are diverse as well as powerful, with Hollywood and the rest prolific in the variety they present of alien forms and doings. A consistent abduction story means that narrators have vacuumed up a surprisingly limited number of these offerings, and more surprisingly still, always the same offerings. Our media-saturated narrators have no reality to constrain them and only their own fantasies to satisfy, yet they repeat largely the same old abduction story despite so many alternatives and variations free for the picking. These abductees are truly a breed apart. Their talent for telling and believing the same whoppers as people they have never met

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ROSWELL: THE MOVIE

BY PAUL DAVIDS

As executive producer and as a longtime friend of CUFOS, I am feeling a mixture of gratitude, relief, and pride as we complete post-production on *Roswell* and look forward to its rendezvous with the public this summer. It took me four and a half years to spring loose the financial support and establishment backing to be able to make *Roswell* as a feature-length dramatic film. And I was unable to do it alone. Producer Ilene Kahn, who won an Emmy in 1993 for her work on *Stalin*, was instrumental, and we were assisted by David Ginsburg of Citadel Pictures. And of course director/producer Jeremy Kagan brought to it vision, talent, and determination to make it happen.

While those years of struggle, frequent rejection, repeated delay, and stoic determination were something of a cruel test—both spiritually and professionally—the outcome was wonderful when Viacom Films finally decided to make this movie for Showtime.

Roswell as a film began when I optioned the rights to Kevin D. Randle and Donald R. Schmitt's *UFO Crash at Roswell* back in 1989, when they were still at work on their book, which I consider an important contribution and something of a milestone achievement. A critical juncture in my efforts occurred in 1991, the day Jeremy Kagan and I met up again, about 20 years after we had begun studying in the same class at school at the American Film Institute. Those were the days when the AFI was located in the Beverly Hills mansion known as Greystone where, together with our contemporaries such as David Lynch, Tim Hunter, Matthew Robbins, Caleb Deschanel, Tom Rickman, Terence Malick, and others, we had plotted and schemed as to how to create a "new world order" of professional filmmaking.

Kagan is best known as director of *The Journey of Natty Gann*, *The Chosen*, *The Big Fix*, *Heroes*, and *The Sting II*, as well as many television movies. I discovered that he was immediately drawn to this subject. It was not out of any fund of UFO knowledge or personal UFO experiences that he responded positively, but rather out of a fascination for the incredible possibilities suggested by such a cosmic cover-up and the awareness that the story suggested a sort of *Rashomon* structure which had great dramatic richness.

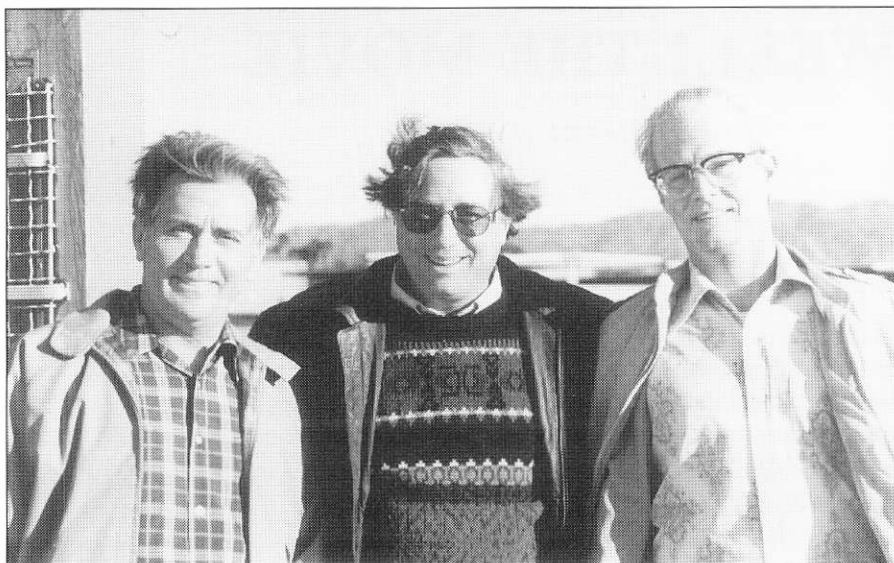
Paul Davids, a producer and writer, lives in Los Angeles with his wife and two children.



Paul Davids in his producer's chair in Bisbee, Arizona, which doubled as the town of Roswell. Arizona locations were chosen in order to be near Tucson as a support city.

Our shared insight into the material told us that this was not a linear, historical narrative but rather a mystery stitched from the pieces of many people's recollections over the passage of time. This gave the material a texture that called to mind Warren Beatty's *Reds*—that is, old people spilling their guts about a long-ago something that had proven crucial in their lives.

For our *Roswell* to work, it was essential that we span the decades. Just to set out to tell what happened in 1947 would have robbed the story of one of its crucial elements—namely, that old men, nearing death, at long last began to share the secret they had been ordered to keep buried for the "good of the nation." But who was to be the main character,



Martin Sheen, Paul Davids, and Kyle MacLachlan (in old-age makeup as the elderly Jesse Marcel).

who could carry the viewer and put together all the pieces of the puzzle?

The answer was found in Maj. Jesse Marcel, who was the scapegoat of the affair and who was never told the full story himself of what had really happened. It gnawed at him for decades. After playwright Arthur Kopit (*Oh Dad, Poor Dad, Mama's Hung You in the Closet and I'm Feeling So Sad*) became involved as screenwriter, the story used elderly Jesse Marcel in 1977 (the year before he started to talk on a wide scale) returning to a reunion of the 509th Bomb Group. There he was determined to pry the rest of the story out of his old colleagues and then tell it all to the world. The events of 1947 are revealed in a series of flashbacks as Marcel approaches his old military companions one by one, with each successive flashback taking the story to deeper levels to portray what the soldiers, a radio announcer, a mortician, a Deep Throat (à la Donald Sutherland in *JFK*) and others believe to be the truth.

OUTLIVING THE COMPETITION

As was widely reported, HBO developed the project for about a year and a half, then decided not to go forward. HBO was not the only major motion-picture company or network to decline to make this movie, but it was the only one to spend hundreds of thousands of dollars and then refuse to make it.

And I was not the only producer to face the strong possibility of failure in the effort to bring a version of the story of the Roswell UFO encounter to the screen. Philippe Mora was the first director to announce it in collaboration with Whitley Strieber. They planned to make *Majestic*, which might have blown us out of the water years ago. But their spaceship crashed in the gully of *Communion*'s poor box-office receipts. Then there was Steven Haft, producer of *Dead Poets Society*, who set up a project about Roswell at Turner Entertainment, which was in competition with ours. It was a race to see which cable movie would get off the ground first. Ironically, Turner dropped its Roswell movie project just a few weeks before HBO

dropped ours.

The list of Roswell projects that crashed on sheeplands like a punctured weather balloon goes on and on, to include Sunn Classics' effort for NBC and others.

I suppose that the bottom line is that I was a survivor, and I'm delighted that was the case.

THE CAST

The movie *Roswell* was accomplished on a respectable scale. We had an outstanding cast and an array of sets, locations, costumes, and literally dozens of period vehicles—from the many World War II planes we used up to



Kevin Randle (dressed to be an extra as a reporter), Jeremy Kagan (director), Paul Davids, and Don Schmitt. They are in the room that was used as Sheriff Wilcox's office.

and including the B-29 bomber, to the score of 1947 cars we used to create a traffic jam of Roswell townspeople trying to get past a military cordon blocking access to the crash site. It also required the creation of some ingenious aliens, which were the work of Steve Johnson, who is noted for creating the *Ghostbusters* ghouls and has done special makeups and built creatures for many films.

Our motion picture, however, dutifully avoids most elements of science-fiction style and instead concentrates on the historical and emotional qualities of the story, especially the personal journey and anguish of Maj. Marcel, the fall guy in the military cover-up. Kyle MacLachlan (of *Dune*, *Twin Peaks*, and *The Hidden*) plays Marcel at two ages separated in time by 30 years, providing the opportunity for a stunning performance.

Martin Sheen joins MacLachlan as our Deep Throat who is called Townsend. Country singer Dwight Yoakam gives a strong, committed performance as rancher Mac Brazel, and Kim Greist (of *Brazil*) plays Mrs. Marcel, both old and young. Other notables in the cast include Peter MacNicol (*Ghostbusters II* and *Addams Family Values*) who portrays Counter-Intelligence Corps officer Lewis Rickett as both a young and an elderly man, Charles Martin Smith (*American Graffiti*, *Never Cry Wolf*, *The Untouchables*) as Sheriff George Wilcox, and Xander Berkeley (*Terminator 2: Judgment Day*) as another real-life CIC agent whom we named Sherman Carson for the film. Nick Searcy (*The Fugitive*) plays young Jesse Marcel, Jr., and Doug Wert plays Jesse, Jr., as a grown man.

John Jackson appears as Col. Blanchard; Bob Gunton as KGFL radio announcer Frank Joyce; David Selburg as KGFL station manager Jud Roberts; Matthew Faison as Gen. Ramey; John Hostetter as Col. Thomas DuBose; Lisa Waltz as a Roswell nurse; Matt Landers as Lt. Walter Haut; and Eugene Roche as a high-ranking member of the Truman cabinet. Beyond these, there are more than 50 other speaking roles in the film.

Fortunately we had the energetic support of persons such as Jesse Marcel, Jr., whose daughter appears as a waitress in one scene in the movie, and Walter Haut, Jud Roberts, and Frank Joyce, who are all portrayed on screen by their real names. Deceased characters also figure prominently, among them DuBose, Rickett (both of whom died in 1993), Sheriff Wilcox, and Mac Brazel.

I should also mention two extras. Kevin Randle can be seen in the background as a news reporter in the sheriff's office when all hell is breaking loose about the flying-saucer announcement in the *Roswell Daily Record*. And Donald Schmitt can be seen as the bartender who gives Marcel a drink when he steps up to the bar to interrogate his old "friend" Sherman Carson.

And then there's me, in a section of the movie dramatizing what Townsend has to say. This part of the story is presented in a way to indicate that it may be the truth or it may be disinformation—but there I am, playing the role of



Paul Davids dressed as a photographer for the 509th. He is photographing the aliens, which are just out of the picture.

the military photographer who takes pictures of the alien corpses in the autopsy room, only to discover that one of them . . . is not deceased.

Though destined for the small screen in the United States when it premieres on the Showtime cable channel in the summer, a big-screen release is expected in Europe and elsewhere.

A QUEST FOR TRUTH

It may be grandiose thinking on my part, but I truly hope our film may join the dramatic niche carved out by such socially explosive movies as *JFK*, *Norma Rae*, *Silkwood*, *To Kill a Mockingbird*, and *Inherit the Wind*. Those now classic films each tackled major social, controversial issues by appealing to the human element of their themes, which concerned respectively: an assassinated President, a struggle to establish a labor union, a nuclear-power cover-up, an innocent black man on trial for raping a white woman, and the public debate over evolution as expressed in a "monkey trial."

To those important themes and stories, I hope we can add that of the ridiculed, publicly humiliated major who methodically and single-handedly goes about shattering the secrecy imposed by a massive UFO cover-up with the combined determination of moviedom's Jim Garrison, Norma Rae, Karen Silkwood, Atticus Finch, and Clarence Darrow. Whether the real Jesse Marcel reached that stature can be a matter for debate, but many people now consider that his revelation of the Roswell cover-up was a noble and decisive act for which one day he will be accorded historical recognition.

What I hope ufologists will most appreciate in our movie is the fact that our Maj. Marcel is on a quest for truth; he is stubborn and determined to succeed at an intense level which even puts him at odds with his own family. "I want the

truth to come out," he declares. "I've been living a lie, and I don't want to die with one."

From the outset, with the strength of Schmitt and Randle's research as the initial basis and inspiration, I viewed the making of this movie as a personal quest. After sighting a disc within about 500 feet (see my "Starry Night," May/June 1989 *IUR*), I found myself more shattered by the human, official denials than I did by the high strangeness of what I saw. But the extreme skepticism I encountered when I talked about the experience probably should not have surprised me. I would probably have been slow to accept it myself if someone else had told me the tale.

Though we haven't yet heard the assessments of our audience, which must await the film's completion, I can say that whatever happens, we had the good fortune to be permitted to make the movie and statement we most wanted to make, as we thought it best to make it. That's an opportunity filmmakers seldom get, since normally bitter and uncomfortable compromises detract from the quality of the vision that gave it birth. But such was not the case this time, and for that I am thankful to all the Viacom and Showtime people who made this unique experience possible. ♦



Kevin Randle and Don Schmitt holding one of the movie's many weather balloons. (Credit: Paul Davids)

LETTERS

EXPERIENCE AND EVENT

To the editor:

The editorial "Wagging the Dog" (*IUR*, January/February) has been a long time coming. It has been a wearisome wait for those of us with a scientific background. It's time now to get rid of the charlatans who crowd the field.

A. Stamulis
Laurel, Maryland

To the editor:

I always expect to find in your writings a serious purpose, a significant theme, and a critical analysis of the factors involved in the topic. I am not disappointed in my expectations—usually. However, I am puzzled by your purpose, topic, and analysis in your "Wagging the Dog."

Am I correct or incorrect in my memory of the 1979 Brazilian UFO Congress? Did I hear J. Allen Hynek describe the dilemma of modern physicists in regard to light? Can light be viewed as *both* particle and wave? Is Hynek's thesis correct that ufologists can view UFO phenomena as both physical events and psychical experiences?

Are your comments about "anomalous event" and "experience anomaly" another version of the particle vs. wave thesis? Are we trying to be more scientific by focusing on

events rather than on experiences? Why not both?

R. Leo Sprinkle, Ph.D.
Laramie, Wyoming

FURTHER SCIENTIFIC STUDY

To the editor:

Chris Rutkowski's "Scientific Studies of Unidentified Flying Objects" (*IUR*, January/February 1994) presents some excellent suggestions for UFO research. However, I felt his thoughts on "natural electromagnetic radiated energy" overlooked many possibilities.

There are frequent cases where automobile ignitions are affected by a UFO; the reasons for this remain unexplained. Also, there would seem to be electrical or electromagnetic factors in Raymond Fowler's Allagash case, in Jacques Vallee's chupas in South America, in the Hudson River Valley sightings of a few years ago, and even in some aspects of the current Linda Cortile case (cars stopped on bridge, light moving on building).

Since most people in the UFO movement seem to believe in the extraterrestrial hypothesis, I suspect they do not wish to investigate alternative possibilities.

Robert Wanderer
San Francisco, California

THE EUROPEAN PARLIAMENT

The European Parliament, at its meeting of December 1, 1993, unanimously passed a resolution to enable the UFO branch of the French government's space agency to carry out UFO investigations throughout the member countries of the European Community (EC). The UFO branch, the Service d'Expertise des Phénomènes de Rentrée Atmosphérique (SEPRA), has been in operation since 1977 under the direction of Jean-Jacques Velasco. The agency was originally called the Groupe d'Etude des Phénomènes Aérospatiaux Non-identifiés (GEPAN), and was responsible for the investigation of the Trans-en-Provence physical trace case.

The resolution was first proposed to the Parliament in 1991 by Elio Di Rupo, a Belgian deputy, in the wake of the Belgian UFO wave. His intention was to set up an all-European agency to collect and analyze UFO reports made by citizens, the military, and scientific organizations. The agency would be run by the Commission of the European Communities and by a standing committee of experts from the twelve member states. However, at some time during the debate the idea arose to extend SEPRA's responsibilities to other European countries, rather than create a new agency. The actual implementation of this proposal was postponed during the Parliament's January session, but the group might be established as early as this summer.

Some of our European colleagues have expressed concern about this situation, even likening it to a European Condon Committee. The French UFO group SOS OVNI has had difficulty coping with the government-sponsored SEPRA. As Perry Petrakis of SOS OVNI puts it: "Velasco sits on a fence between officialdom, which ties his hands, and his own unofficial profound belief in extraterrestrials. . . . Although Velasco never refuses appearances in the media, he carefully avoids annoying questions by keeping a low profile in French ufology." Also, SEPRA has not published any research reports since 1983 and does not seem to be involved in many of the interesting French cases over the past few years. Petrakis pointed out that if SEPRA had been given a European status two years ago, "then SOBEPS in Belgium would not have had any exchange with the Belgian authorities [after the Belgian UFO wave]. Their reply would have been: 'Please refer to SEPRA.' English researchers wouldn't have managed the breakthrough with AS2. The policy would have been: 'Please refer to SEPRA.' V. J. Ballester Olmos would not have managed to get a declassification of military files in Spain. Their comment would have been, as it is nowadays in France, everywhere: 'Please refer to SEPRA.' After all, that was what the French Air Force replied to Euro deputy Tulio Regge."

The potential for SEPRA turning into a European black hole where information is sucked in and no light is ever shed

on the UFO phenomenon is in sharp contrast to the optimism of the European Parliament's proposal. At this time it is unclear whether the Parliament would modify its resolution to allow another agency to be established. For more information on the debate, write to SOS OVNI, Boîte Postale 324, 13611 Aix-en-Provence Cédex 1, France.

Some of the more interesting statements from the *Report of the Committee on Energy, Research and Technology on the Proposal to Set Up a European Centre for Sightings of Unidentified Flying Objects* are reprinted here:

Out of the hundreds interviewed, there was only one Alitalia steward who described an encounter with a UFO on a flight from Rome to Venice. Owing to a violent downpour, the aircraft could not land at Tesserà airport and had to fly on to Ronchi. As it began its descent, three green spheres of light, probably about 100m away, came into view alongside it. The spheres also left traces on the ground radar and were seen by passengers.

In this case, which is similar to others recorded elsewhere, there is no cause to doubt the witness's honesty. . . .

The rapporteur has also written to the air forces of all the Member States and has received a detailed reply from the Italian air force staff, who sent an unclassified summary of all the sightings recorded in the last decade. A peak was reached in 1982, when there were 32 sightings. Generally speaking, it appears that UFOs are sighted in greater numbers along the Italian coasts. The brochure offers no explanations as to the nature of the UFOs and does not refer in any case to sightings made by military personnel. It can thus be described more accurately as a compilation of various eyewitness accounts obtained by the Italian air force.

The French air force sent a polite reply suggesting that the rapporteur contact SEPRA, with which it had been cooperating actively for some time. Other air forces have either not replied or else have refused to help, stating that the information was classified (Spain) and in any event of no great consequence or that I had written to the wrong office (FRG)—but without saying which office I should have written to. More recently, the Spanish air force declassified the information and released a list of sightings, including one which bears some resemblance to the Alitalia case mentioned above. For years air forces in all countries kept UFO sightings secret because they were afraid—a fear which has subsequently proved completely groundless—that the UFOs were caused by secret weapons deployed by the USSR, while the USSR in turn, for similar but opposite reasons, kept its own data secret.

—George M. Eberhart

THE ROSWELL DECLARATION

The following introduction and Declaration are unusual items for *IUR* to publish, but we believe are important enough to bring them to the attention of all CUFOS Associates. The *Roswell Declaration*, as explained more fully in the introduction, is designed as a vehicle to place pressure on the government, specifically members of Congress and the President, to authorize the release of government information regarding the existence of UFOs or extraterrestrial intelligence. Drafted by Kent Jeffrey, who is a principal supporter of the Roswell investigation, the Declaration is being publicized by several methods, including publication in UFO periodicals, lectures, talk shows, and on various computer bulletin boards and the Internet. There is also a plan to distribute the Declaration in Europe and eventually to all other countries whose citizens have an interest in the UFO phenomenon. The editors of *IUR* urge you to read the *Roswell Declaration* closely and, if you agree with its purpose, to sign and return a copy to CUFOS.—*The Editors*.

INTRODUCTION

The *Roswell Declaration* is part of a worldwide effort to end U.S. government secrecy surrounding the 1947 Roswell incident. It contains an appeal to the Administration for an Executive Order to declassify any U.S. government information on UFOs or extraterrestrial intelligence. You can help by signing and returning a copy of the declaration.

The effort is being supported by three independent nonprofit organizations devoted to the serious study of the UFO phenomenon. The membership of the governing committees of these organizations consists primarily of researchers, scientists, and Ph.Ds. The three organizations are the Center for UFO Studies (CUFOS), 2457 W. Peterson Avenue, Chicago, IL 60659; the Mutual UFO Network (MUFON), 103 Oldtowne Road, Seguin, TX 78155; and the Fund for UFO Research (FUFOR), P.O. Box 277, Mt. Ranier, MD 20712.

Additionally, UFO organizations throughout the world are involved in a drive to obtain signatures from scientists, professionals, and the general public in support of the *Roswell Declaration*. On a yet-to-be-determined day later this year, the news media in different countries around the world will be notified and furnished with material about the Roswell incident in an effort to bring international attention to the Roswell case.

On that same day, a copy of the *Roswell Declaration*,

along with a listing of the total number of signatories from each of the fifty states as well as from other countries, will be delivered to the offices of all members of Congress and to the White House. Also on that day, if finances permit, a copy of the *Roswell Declaration* will be placed in the first section of the national edition of a major U.S. newspaper as well as in other major newspapers around the world.

Polls have shown that more than 50% of the people in the United States believe in the reality of UFOs and extraterrestrial intelligence. Unfortunately, that interest has never been galvanized into a large-scale grassroots movement. With the *Roswell Declaration*, this may now become a reality.

Since this will be primarily a word-of-mouth, grassroots effort, your help in making copies of the declaration and distributing them to as many people as possible will be of great importance. The declaration is being made available on computer bulletin boards throughout the world. A five-page position paper, "Time for the Truth About Roswell," from which the declaration is derived, will also be made available. The position paper includes a detailed summary of the Roswell event, an analysis of the media and government treatment of it, and arguments for allowing the public to know the truth.

The position paper and the declaration were written by Kent Jeffrey of Fairfax, California. Jeffrey has researched the Roswell event extensively, worked with several of the leading investigators, and interviewed a number of the Roswell witnesses. He is an international airline pilot whose interest in the Roswell case stems in part from the fact that his father, a retired colonel and former air force pilot (and WWII fighter ace), at one time knew and worked with one of the key Roswell figures, General William Blanchard.

Although it is felt by the organizers of this effort that there is a high degree of probability the U.S. government is withholding information regarding the existence of extraterrestrial intelligence, the primary goal is to get the matter into the open so that the truth can be conclusively determined, one way or the other. It is hoped, therefore, that all individuals, no matter what their opinion on the subject, will support this effort.

Please send signed declarations to:

CUFOS
2457 West Peterson Avenue
Chicago, IL 60659

ROSWELL DECLARATION 1994

Forty-seven years ago an incident occurred in the southwestern desert of the United States that could have significant implications for all mankind. It involved the recovery by the U.S. military of material alleged to be of extraterrestrial origin. The event was announced by the U.S. military on July 8, 1947, through a press release that was carried by newspapers throughout the country. It was subsequently denied by what is now believed to be a cover story claiming the material was nothing more than a weather balloon. It has remained veiled in government secrecy ever since.

The press release announcing the unusual event was issued by the Commander of the 509th Bomb Group at Roswell Army Air Field, Colonel William Blanchard, who later went on to become a four-star general and Vice Chief of Staff of the United States Air Force. That the weather balloon story was a cover-up has been confirmed by individuals directly involved, including the late General Thomas DuBose who took the telephone call from Washington, D.C., ordering the cover-up. Numerous other credible military and civilian witnesses have testified that the original press release was correct and that the Roswell wreckage was of extraterrestrial origin. One such individual was Major Jesse Marcel, the Intelligence Officer of the 509th Bomb Group and one of the first military officers at the scene.

On January 12, 1994, U.S. Congressman Steven Schiff of Albuquerque, New Mexico, announced to the press that he had been stonewalled by the Defense Department when requesting information on the 1947 Roswell event on behalf of constituents and witnesses. Indicating that he was seeking further investigation into the matter, Congressman Schiff called the Defense Department's lack of response "astound-

ing" and concluded it was apparently "another government cover-up."

History has shown that unsubstantiated official assurances or denials by government are often meaningless. Nevertheless, there is a logical and straightforward way to ensure that the truth about Roswell will emerge: *an Executive Order declassifying any information regarding the existence of UFOs or extraterrestrial intelligence*. Because this is a unique issue of universal concern, such an action would be appropriate and warranted. To provide positive assurance for all potential witnesses, it would need to be clearly stated and written into law. Such a measure is essentially what presidential candidate Jimmy Carter promised and then failed to deliver to the American people eighteen years ago in 1976.

If, as is officially claimed, no information on Roswell, UFOs, or extraterrestrial intelligence is being withheld, an Executive Order declassifying it would be a mere formality, as there would be nothing to disclose. The Order would, however, have the positive effect of setting the record straight once and for all. Years of controversy and suspicion would be ended, both in the eyes of the United States' own citizens and in the eyes of the world.

If, on the other hand, the Roswell witnesses are telling the truth and information on extraterrestrial intelligence does exist, it is not something to which a privileged few in the United States government should have exclusive rights. It is knowledge of profound importance to which all people throughout the world should have an inalienable right. Its release would unquestionably be universally acknowledged as an historic act of honesty and goodwill.

I support the request, as outlined above, for an Executive Order declassifying any U.S. government information regarding the existence of UFOs or extraterrestrial intelligence. Whether such information exists or whether it does not, I feel that the people of the world have a right to know the truth about this issue and that it is time to put an end to the controversy surrounding it.

Signature _____ Date _____

Name (please print) _____

Street _____

City _____ State _____ Zip _____

Occupation / Title _____ Degrees/Credentials _____

U.S. Representative (if known) _____

MISSING SCIENCE—*continued from page 14*

contradicts everything we know about fantasizers, and signals that the skeptics in their never-ending search for conventional solutions have discovered a mystery more unconventional than spacefaring aliens.

Memory, the authors remind us, is both creative and recreative (p. 217). Why should memory—or fantasy or confabulation—fail to operate according to well-established custom when the subject is abductions? The consistency of these reports ought to strike anyone as peculiar enough to investigate, but the authors stare down this growling anomaly without the least perturbation. Certainty euthanizes curiosity. Yet even in the presence of the corpse, they seem to feel that something is not quite right when they say “the fantasy-prone abductees’ stories would be much more credible if some of them . . . reported the aliens as eight feet tall, red-striped octopeds riding bicycles, and intent upon eating us for dessert” (p. 223). For once we agree. I could sooner believe these stories originated in fantasy if I saw some evidence of fantasy at work. Just because the claim of abduction is fantastic does not prove that it originates in fantasy or hoax. The burden of proof lies with the claimant, but a skeptical hypothesis wins by default only when evidence to the contrary is lacking. Once such evidence as unexpected consistency enters into play, skeptics also owe a debt of reckoning in defense of their position, and mere declarations of faith fail to pay the bill.

A final criticism aimed at me is supposed to seal my doom. It follows from my own words when I acknowledge that hypnosis is no truth serum (p. 232). If I understand this well-justified scientific consensus and still take abductions seriously, then I must be a true believer. Once I am slapped with this dreaded label, the reader should take for granted that I hang up my ability to think at the door. The truth is a little less dramatic. What interests me about hypnosis is the surprising discovery that abduction reports remain consistent, when scientific studies lead me to expect rampant variation. I do not know what abductions are, so any useful clues are welcome. This anomaly of unexpected consistency points beyond the explanatory scope of confabulation to something more, its nature and character uncertain. Hardly a wild surmise, this reason is actually quite modest. Yet readers will find no mention of it anywhere in the book. Sound reasons to take abductions seriously seem to have fallen as casualties along the way and scarcely a survivor stirs in the final text. On the other hand I am fitted up after the fact with an unsound explanation for my interest, trumpeted across the page with considerable fanfare as though missionary angels speak revelations in an oracular voice. This example of how far wrong armchair analysis of motives can go calls to mind the good advice of Sgt. Friday from “Dragnet”—just the facts, ma’am, just the facts.

The treatment of abductions in this book succeeds grandly—as an unflinching disappointment. We readers finish

the first section full of high expectations, with our sense of the right way to investigate elevated well above the amateurish standards ufologists all too often accept. In the flush of such expectations we want to see these techniques applied to the most fantastic and difficult aspect of the UFO phenomenon. We wish to see the machinery of inquiry break down every support for a genuine phenomenon step by step, and tie up loose ends in a tidy bundle. Wanting that ultimate thoroughness, a persuasive case against abductions that addresses the full evidence with fairness will do nicely.

Both hopes prove hopeless. Where are the tests of abductees or their narratives? The interviews? The fieldwork? The basic firsthand engagement with the subject matter that any investigation worthy of the name should undertake? They exist, but it is the ufologists who listen, question, and test, the supposedly unscientific faction that has attempted a scientific approach, while skeptics follow in the footsteps of medieval theologians to find answers by speculation and argument from authority. A naive reader would finish the book innocent that anyone ever dreamed of careful inquiries. What we read are selective findings and opinions, without all the facts or a fair hearing of the opposition to balance the argument. The proponents’ case appears as a caricature suitable for framing and worthy only of ridicule, the proponents themselves dismissed as unqualified bumbler pressing a crackpot agenda. If psychologists, psychiatrists, or anyone else with credentials of some merit pay attention to the phenomenon and express interest in it, their interest disqualifies them and proves their findings worthless. What an irony that a book about investigation should diagnose psychological conditions and draw such absolute conclusions without resort to it.

The authors mean their book to further scientific investigation and scientific rationality. The reader leaves with a sense of uneasiness, of an inner strain never resolved. The reason may be that the book undertakes two missions, an educational one at center stage and an ideological one in the background, when the two are ultimately irreconcilable. As devout rationalists the authors prescribe an admirable ideal for investigators. As skeptics they claim the mantle of rational and principled inquiry, but leave readers good cause to wonder. With evidence ignored, investigation forgone, and “heads I win, tails you lose, arguments abounding, a preference for debaters’ stratagems and lawyers’ tricks seems to drive out the impartial scrutiny of science. A prior certainty about results nullifies the need for science altogether. The underlying goal seems to be to discredit the phenomenon rather than understand it, win an argument rather than find out the truth. This conflict of interests between objective inquiry and ideological crusade tears at the heart of this book.

All too much of what we read furthers the crusade at the expense of the science. Besides a determination not to investigate UFOs seriously, the authors are hardly secretive about their hostility toward the subject. Square in the middle

of their underlying philosophy is a public assumption that the paranormal is a waste of time. Skeptical investigators stand to gain no new knowledge from these claims, but address them only as a necessary rearguard action to defend the tenuous foothold of rational thought against the vigorous resurgence of pseudoscientific credulity in modern society. Paranormal claims reduce to conventional terms, and the investigator's job is to demonstrate how an appearance of mystery arises out of error, delusion, and deception, the superstition and unreason so rampant in popular belief.

With these presuppositions science easily takes a back seat to polemics. Bubbling to the top now and then come blood and thunder tirades such as the following (p. 233):

Other problems with the UFO and abduction literature is [sic] that it is false, misleading, rabble-rousing, sensationalistic, and opportunistically money-grubbing—taking advantage of people's hopes and fears and diverting them from more scientific studies and endeavors.

This sort of red fuming nitric acid lies just under the surface from the first page to the last, and these invectives sputter into print often enough to confuse readers who expect the voice of reason to speak with a moderate tone. At least tirades need not be accurate. To set the record straight, I can attest that contributing to UFO literature is a poor way to grub money. Perhaps the best proof is the vanishing few ufologists who give up their day jobs to maintain the eating habit on profits from UFO pursuits. And how can such literature rouse rabble when skeptics seldom read it before they condemn it?

Words as vitriolic as these belong to a tent revival, a televangelist's rant. We can all deplore the failings of the educational system, the rise of ignorance, unreason, and hostility toward science. We can also keep the matter in perspective and see that the sky is not falling and civilization is not coming to an end on a flood of UFO literature. Rational thought will survive baseless crazes better than it will survive friends who debase its principles in book-length indignation meetings.

Whether it can survive endless bouts of bickering and chest-beating is less certain. Ufologists may well be wrong, but wrong is not necessarily evil. An extremist might portray the relationship between ufologists and skeptics as a conflict between the powers of Darkness and the powers of Light, but closed minds and polarized opinions on either side get nowhere. Demonizing one another simply earns us standing room among the enemies of science in the rites of unreason. A more charitable eye sees the coexistence of seekers groping in the dark toward truth, both sides sharing the same scientific ideals and both sides falling short in application. Good intentions are not enough. Right practice has to follow right intentions, fidelity to evidence and fair judgment has to supplant baseless assertions and overheated rhetoric, or our audience leaves unpersuaded, with a bitter aftertaste and an inclination to wish a plague on both our houses. ♦

HILL—continued from page 6

this back in September 1961. I was a professionally trained social worker, working in this field [as a social worker]. I knew of cases where hypnosis had been used to remove amnesia. About that time, a teen-age boy came home from school and shot to death his whole family, but could not remember this. Under medical hypnosis, he re-acted their murders and could recall his behavior. This is medical hypnosis and is not seen by the public . . . My concern was to find a COMPETENT psychiatrist—one who knew how to use medical hypnosis, third stage.

Clearly Betty, who knew about the use of hypnosis to recover memories in medical work and criminal investigations, was hopeful that Barney's mental block could be removed by the same technique. It is important to note that there is no suggestion of an abduction by nonhuman beings in Betty's letter; instead, her suggestion for hypnosis was to help Barney overcome his fright and learn about what he saw that morning. Still, the significant historical fact is that the first suggestion of hypnosis in an American case came from the witness, not the investigator.

I also asked Betty about whether she knew why Fuller deleted the critical sentence from her letter. She replied, "I assume he may have felt it was not needed, as he planned to write [about] our meeting with Jim MacDonald, and to write more about hypnosis," a statement entirely consistent with my hypothesis about Fuller's motives.

In all this we should remember the distinction between an author who happens to be writing about UFOs and a UFO investigator who happens to be writing a book. Professional writers, while generally concerned with truth and accuracy, do not have these as their only goals—else they won't long remain writers. They must, as has been my experience with publications about UFOs as well as other topics, be very concerned with crafting a dramatic, exciting book that sells well (and no one can blame them in this, since their livelihood depends on those sales). UFO investigators who write books, beginning in the 1950s with Major Keyhoe, usually are more concerned with accuracy, in my judgment, and less interested in dramatic structure. If these observations have merit, then the actions of Fuller are more comprehensible. Nonetheless, Fuller's deletion from Betty's letter underscores the importance of examining primary case documents whenever possible (recall the confusion in published accounts about when the missing time was discovered). I also believe this article illustrates nicely the benefit of reinvestigating older reports.

DREAMS

Sometime in the month of November 1961, Betty wrote five pages of single-spaced notes describing the strange and vivid dreams she began having about ten days to two weeks

after the incident. Fuller, to his credit, did publish a full transcript of these notes, although he relegated them to an appendix. It is worth recalling these notes today because of the great similarity between them and the details that later emerged under hypnosis (I invite the reader to read *The Interrupted Journey* and compare the dreams to the hypnotic transcripts). As Budd Hopkins, David Jacobs, and other investigators have repeatedly stated, hypnosis is often not necessary to recover details about the abduction experience. This feature of abduction cases, like so many others, can thus also be found in the Hill case. Since the Hill case was the first in the United States, the significance of Betty's dreams was not obvious to the NICAP investigators; but now, after hundreds of abduction cases, the idea that the experience can emerge through dreams is widely accepted.

Betty's suggestion that hypnosis be used in the investigation and her vivid dreams that foreshadowed what emerged under hypnosis do not tell us conclusively whether or not the Hills' experience was real. These details do demonstrate that many of the essential features of abduction accounts, as documented most exhaustively by Bullard, were present at the beginning, in the first abduction report. ♦

EDITORIAL—continued from page 3

If one wants to predict a possibly dire outcome, given the nature of the GAO inquiry, imagine the military responding to the GAO that, yes, there are records about Roswell, but they remain properly classified and sealed from public view. In that case, the government did indeed follow proper procedures for classifying and retaining records, especially if the Roswell event was caused by something rather extraordinary—so, end of the GAO inquiry. But the GAO investigators have the highest security clearances (they are senior personnel), so that argument can hardly work with them. If nothing else, the government would have to explain why they (the GAO investigators) could not be told about the Roswell event, even if that information could not be declassified. To learn some bit of classified information, both the appropriate security clearance and a need-to-know are necessary. The GAO investigators have the first, and the government would have to demonstrate why they don't have the second.

There have been reports in the media and recently in the *MUFON UFO Journal* that a certain Col. Larry G. Shockley in the Defense Department has not been cooperative with the GAO investigation, even expressing active hostility. I found this rather hard to believe—you don't want to irritate an agency like the GAO that has investigative powers and with whom you will probably have to work in the future on a non-UFO related matter. So I asked the GAO about these reports, and they told me that the Defense Department has been cooperative with their investigation and that no hostility has been expressed, which is good news for us all.

The GAO has no particular timetable for completion of

the investigation, though it would be normal for them to brief Rep. Schiff or his staff periodically about their work. It is also worth noting that at this time, and perhaps surprisingly, the GAO investigators have no interest in speaking to witnesses to the crash, the military recovery operation, the debris, or other events related to the incident. This position, though, is understandable, as eyewitness testimony about the crash itself has no direct bearing on whether the military correctly created and maintained records on the events at Roswell or similar incidents.

I came away from my conversation with an appreciation for the professionalism and dedication of the GAO investigators. They are approaching this inquiry as they would any other (difficult at times, I'm sure, given the unusual topic).

Rep. Schiff's interest in Roswell and the GAO inquiry have already begun to have an effect on government willingness to discuss the event. Col. James Miller, the current commander of the Air Force Foreign Aerospace Science and Technology Center, was recently quoted as saying that officials at Wright-Patterson AFB have extensively searched for evidence related to the Roswell event but found nothing. Officials have never before admitted to such a search.

The GAO inquiry is an historic and important event for ufology. It is the second Congressionally-initiated UFO investigation (the first was the ill-fated Condon Committee in the late 1960s), not counting scattered hearings. Although small in scale, and not confined solely to UFO reports or Roswell, it is possibly the most serious, open-minded inquiry into UFOs by the government since the days of Edward Ruppelt at Project Blue Book in the early 1950s (and Ruppelt was hampered by lack of resources and other constraints). At this point, the UFO community must be patient and await the outcome of the GAO investigation (while still vigorously continuing our own independent efforts). I wish them the best of luck.

WHAT CAN YOU DO TO HELP?

If you would like to support efforts aimed at learning the truth about Roswell, there are several actions you can take.

1. Write to your member of Congress, telling him or her that you support Rep. Schiff's inquiry and asking for the member to lend direct support and encouragement to Schiff.
2. Sign the *Roswell Declaration* printed in this issue of *IUR* and written by Kent Jeffrey.
3. Write to Rep. Schiff himself and tell him that you support his inquiry.
4. Tell your friends and colleagues about the Roswell event and, if they are interested, encourage them to write to Congress, too.

—Mark Rodeghier